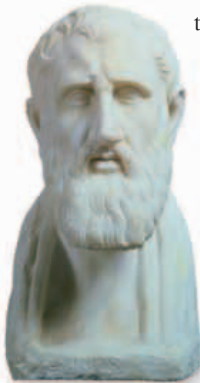


Classical Thought

During the 5th century BCE, under the brilliant leadership of Pericles, the city-state of Athens rose to become the political and cultural focus of the Greek world. The thinkers who lived and taught there prepared the ground for much of Western philosophy for the next 2000 years.

Philosophy is a method of rational inquiry used to attempt to understand the world and phenomena around us; it is also the study of the process of philosophical inquiry itself. Three philosophers who taught in Athens are credited with laying the foundations of all classical thought—Socrates, Plato, and Aristotle.



ZENO THE STOIC
Zeno is said to have strangled himself at the age of 69, in accordance with the Stoic belief that a man has the right to determine his own death.

Socrates

Socrates was born around 470 BCE, and became famous for challenging conventional ideas that most people thought they understood. He did this by questioning what was meant by concepts such as “good,” “evil,” “courage,” and “justice,” to show people that their understanding of such terms lacked truth. He wrote nothing down, but his logical style of argument is portrayed in the works of his followers, particularly Plato and the soldier and historian Xenophon. His greatest concern was ethics, or how to live a good life. At the age of 70 his constant questioning was thought to threaten the Athenian state. He was condemned to death, and was forced to poison himself.

Plato

A follower of Socrates, Plato was born c. 428 BCE and developed his mentor's ideas. Many of his writings, such as *Symposium* and the *Republic*, were composed as dialogues on subjects such as ethics and justice, the nature of reality, and the immortality of the soul. He also tried to devise a perfect political system. He set up a school, called the Academy, on the outskirts of Athens, which continued to teach philosophy until the 6th century CE.

Aristotle

Plato's student Aristotle (see p.95) taught a different kind of philosophy from that of his master—more practical than theoretical—and insisted on the importance of observing facts (see pp.104–05). He spent three years as

tutor to Alexander the Great (see pp.96–99), whose conquests spread Greek ideas widely in Asia and North Africa. Aristotle founded his own school outside Athens called the Lyceum. His books, compiled from lecture notes, covered subjects ranging from poetry, drama, ethics, and politics to mathematics, physics, logic, zoology, and anatomy. They remained the basis of Western and Islamic science and philosophy until the 17th century.

Many philosophical movements emerged from the work of Socrates, Plato, and Aristotle. Among the most important were

Skepticism, Cynicism, Epicureanism, and Stoicism—the last two had the most enduring influence.

SKEPTICISM A philosophical movement that denied the possibility of knowing the real truth with certainty.

CYNICISM A philosophy that taught that virtue and asceticism, rather than pleasure and indulgence, led to happiness.

Epicureanism and Stoicism

Epicurus (born 341 BCE) taught that good and bad should be measured by the pleasure and pain they bring, and that the point of justice is to increase human happiness. He believed that the gods, if they exist at all, had no interest in human affairs and that there was no life after death. He thought that



Remembering mortality

Epicureans used the skull as a *memento mori* (which means “remember that you are mortal”) to remind them of the importance of enjoying life while it is still possible.

events in the world were the result of the motion of atoms in empty space—an idea he possibly borrowed from Democritus (born 460 BCE). The Latin poet Lucretius brought Epicurus's ideas to the Roman world, where they strongly influenced writers like Virgil.

Stoicism was founded by Zeno of Citium (born 335 BCE). He divided philosophy into three elements: logic, physics, and ethics. He believed that underlying all matter was energy, which he called divine fire. Zeno claimed that universal human fellowship was more important than narrow loyalty and that man's duty was to accept what fate brings and to behave in accordance with nature.

Stoicism was an inspiration to the Romans who took over the Greek world from the 2nd century BCE (see pp.106–07). Roman thinkers such as Seneca the Younger, Cicero, and Cato the Younger adapted Stoic ideas to the new realities of the Roman Empire. The Roman values of bravery in battle, fortitude in the face of hardship, and the universal brotherhood of Roman citizenship owe their origins to the teachings of the Stoics.

Greek philosophical ideas became the common heritage of intellectuals in the Mediterranean world and beyond, well into the Roman period.

THE ROMAN ARISTOTLE

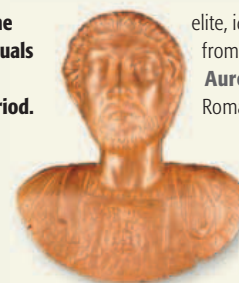
The Romans elaborated on Greek ideas. **Pliny the Elder** (born 24 CE) added to Aristotle's natural history and **Claudius Ptolemy** (born c. 90 CE) gave Aristotle's astronomy mathematical treatment. The poet **Horace** (born 65 BCE) was known as the Roman Aristotle for his analysis of literature and drama.

NEOPLATONISM

Plato's teachings on the nature of reality became a renewed doctrine—**Neoplatonism**—with **Plotinus** (born c. 205 CE). This had a **profound influence on Christian theology**, particularly through **St. Augustine** (born 354 CE), whose Neoplatonist ideas survived his conversion to Christianity.

MARCUS AURELIUS

Stoicism found a welcome in Rome, where it became the most popular philosophy among the



MARCUS AURELIUS

elite, idealizing self-control and detachment from emotion. The Emperor **Marcus Aurelius** (born 121 CE) gave expression to Roman Stoicism in his book *Meditations*.

LATER EPICUREANISM

In the US Declaration of Independence (1776) **298–99** >>, the right to “**life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness**” is an Epicurean ideal.



ST. AUGUSTINE AT THE SCHOOL OF ROME

IDEA

CONFUCIANISM

In China, Confucius (according to tradition, born 551 BCE) addressed ethical questions similar to those that concerned the Greeks. He emphasized truth, justice, correct social relations, and obedience to parents, believing that the family was the proper foundation for society and good government. He championed the golden rule: “Do not do unto others what you would not want for yourself.” His collected sayings, *The Analects*, found a similar place in Eastern thought to Plato's *Republic* in the West.



AFTER

